NEW HAMPSHIRE

The Granite State



New Hampshire has never been a place that rewarded softness. Its winters arrive early and stay long, pressing down from the White Mountains through the river valleys and into the mill towns that rose along the Merrimack in the 19th century. It was in those towns—Manchester, Nashua, Concord—that the working people of New Hampshire built their lives around labor, practicality, and the kind of cooking that could sustain a body through a brutal February without complaint.

The Irish came first, driven across the Atlantic by the Great Famine of the 1840s, arriving in New England with little more than the memory of what home had tasted like. They found work in the granite quarries of Conway and Milford, on the railroad lines pushing north toward the White Mountains, and on the floors of the great textile mills of Manchester—at the time, home to the Amoskeag Manufacturing Company, one of the largest cotton mills in the world. The work was hard, the hours were long, and the pay demanded careful eating.

Corned beef had been a practical staple in Ireland for centuries, though ironically it was more often exported by the Irish than eaten by them. In America, it became theirs in a new way. Brisket, salt-cured and affordable, was sold cheaply at the butcher shops that lined Elm Street in Manchester's Irish neighborhood—the dense, close-knit Irish enclave where families packed into tenement blocks and kept one another alive through difficult winters. A woman could drop a well-corned brisket into a heavy pot with root vegetables—the cabbage, carrots, potatoes, and turnips that stored well through the cold months in a root cellar—and feed her family for two days from a single afternoon of cooking.

The French Canadians arrived next, streaming south from Quebec through the Connecticut River Valley and into the mill towns, bringing their own traditions of hearty, economical cooking. They recognized something familiar in the boiled dinner—a technique not unlike their own pot-au-feu—and it absorbed quietly into the broader New Hampshire table, shared across tenement hallways and church suppers without much ceremony.

By the early 20th century, the New Hampshire boiled dinner had become something larger than any single community. It appeared on church fundraiser menus in Concord, at Grange Hall suppers in the rural towns of Grafton County, and on the kitchen stoves of farmhouses from the Lakes Region to the Connecticut River. It was the kind of dish that asked nothing of you but time—and rewarded that time with a pot full of something deeply satisfying, the broth rich and rosy, the meat tender enough to pull apart with a fork, the vegetables soft and soaked through with flavor.

That same honest, unhurried reward is waiting for you here. There is something quietly thrilling about lifting the lid on a pot that has been doing its slow work all afternoon—the steam rising, the smell filling every corner of the kitchen, the knowledge that what's inside needs nothing more than a sharp knife and a hungry table. This is cooking at its most generous. Make it on a cold Saturday, invite people you like, and don't rush a single minute of it.

CORNED BEEF BOILED DINNER

Salt-cured beef and humble vegetables surrender slowly to the simmer, filling the kitchen with a warmth that feels like coming home.

Yield: 6–8 servings

INGREDIENTS

- 1 (3–4 lb.) corned beef brisket, with seasoning packet
- 12 cups cold water (or enough to cover meat)
- 1 large onion, peeled and quartered
- 4 cloves garlic, smashed
- 2 bay leaves
- 1 tsp black peppercorns
- 3 medium turnips or rutabagas, peeled and cut into wedges
- 6 medium carrots, peeled and cut into 2–3-inch chunks
- 3 beets, peeled and cut into chunks (cook separately, if you like, to keep the broth from turning red)
- 6 medium potatoes (Yukon Gold or red), scrubbed and halved
- 4 parsnips, peeled and cut into chunks (optional but traditional)
- 1 small green cabbage, cut into wedges
- Dijon or whole-grain mustard, to serve
- 1 bunch fresh parsley, for garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Simmer the meat*: Place the corned beef brisket in a large stockpot. Add onion, garlic, bay leaves, peppercorns, and enough water to cover by 2 inches. Bring to a boil, then reduce to a gentle simmer. Cover loosely and cook for 2½–3 hours, or until the beef is fork-tender. Skim foam as needed.
2. *Cook root vegetables*: Add turnips or rutabagas and carrots to the pot. Add the beets, or cook them in a separate pot. Simmer for 20 minutes.
3. *Add potatoes and parsnips*: Stir in potatoes and parsnips. Simmer another 15 minutes. Add cabbage wedges on top. Cook 15 minutes more, or until all vegetables are tender but not falling apart.
4. *Rest the meat*: Remove the brisket to a cutting board, tent with foil, and let rest for 10 minutes.
5. *Slice and serve*: Slice corned beef against the grain. Arrange on a platter surrounded by the vegetables. Garnish with parsley. Serve hot with mustard on the side.

